PADHAKU
Footprints without Feet · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 1

A Triumph of Surgery

NCERT Exercise Solutions

A Triumph of Surgery · Read and Find Out (1) — 3 Q

A Triumph of Surgery · Read and Find Out (2) — 4 Q

A Triumph of Surgery · Think about it — 3 Q

A Triumph of Surgery · Talk about it — 4 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ A Triumph of Surgery · Read and Find Out (1)

1 **Why is Mrs Pumphrey worried about Tricki?**

✔ ANSWER

Tricki had become hugely fat, "like a bloated sausage with a leg at each corner". He was **listless**, had no energy, and his eyes were bloodshot and rheumy. Mrs Pumphrey thought he was weak and suffering from malnutrition.

2 **What does she do to help him? Is she wise in this?**

✔ ANSWER

She gives him extras between meals — malt, cod-liver oil and a bowl of Horlicks at night — and also cream cakes and chocolates because she cannot refuse him.

No, she is not wise. Tricki's real problem was overeating and lack of exercise, so the extra food only made him more ill.

3 **Who does 'I' refer to in this story?**

✔ ANSWER

'I' refers to the narrator, **Mr James Herriot**, the veterinary surgeon who treats Tricki.

⭐ A Triumph of Surgery · Read and Find Out (2)

1 **Is the narrator as rich as Tricki's mistress?**

✔ ANSWER

No. He is not as rich as Mrs Pumphrey. She has a large house, many servants, a chauffeur and a long car, while the narrator and his partners were delighted to get free eggs, wine and brandy.

2 **How does he treat the dog?**

✔ ANSWER

He treats Tricki sensibly, with no medicine. For two days he gives him no food, only plenty of water. Then he lets him play and run with the other dogs and eat a normal share with them. Tricki becomes fit through diet and exercise.

3 **Why is he tempted to keep Tricki on as a permanent guest?**

✔ ANSWER

Because Mrs Pumphrey kept sending fresh eggs, wine and brandy "to build up Tricki's strength". The narrator and his partners enjoyed these luxuries, so it was tempting to keep Tricki longer.

4 **Why does Mrs Pumphrey think the dog's recovery is "a triumph of surgery"?**

✔ ANSWER

She does not know that Tricki was cured only by a strict diet and exercise. Seeing his amazing change in two weeks, she believes the vet must have done some great medical treatment or operation, so she calls it "a triumph of surgery".

🤔 A Triumph of Surgery · Think about it

1 **What kind of a person do you think the narrator, a veterinary surgeon, is? Would you say he is tactful as well as full of common sense?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The narrator, Mr Herriot, is a kind, caring and sensible vet.

- **Common sense:** he sees that Tricki's only illness is overeating and lack of exercise, and cures him with no medicine — just fasting, a normal diet and play with other dogs.
- **Tactful:** he does not blame Mrs Pumphrey directly. He takes Tricki to the hospital for "observation" so she cannot overfeed him. He dodges her silly questions about cushions and coats and only tells her that Tricki is "convalescing rapidly".

- **Honest and kind:** though tempted by the eggs, wine and brandy, he returns Tricki after a fortnight because he knows Mrs Pumphrey is suffering.

So yes, he is both tactful and full of common sense.

2 **Do you think Tricki was happy to go home? What do you think will happen now?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Yes, Tricki was happy to see his mistress. He leapt from the vet's arms into Mrs Pumphrey's lap and licked her face, barking. He loved her.

But he had also enjoyed his life with the other dogs. Now, if Mrs Pumphrey goes back to overfeeding him with cakes and chocolates and gives him no exercise, he will become fat and ill again. If she has learnt her lesson, he will stay healthy.

3 **Do you think this is a real-life episode, or mere fiction? Or is it a mixture of both?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

It seems to be a mixture of both. James Herriot was a real vet, and pampered pets and over-loving owners are common in real life. But some details are exaggerated for humour, such as Tricki's whole wardrobe of coats, the "thirty feet" long car and the eggs, wine and brandy sent for a dog. So it is a real-life experience told with some fiction and humour.

⭐ A Triumph of Surgery · Talk about it

1 **This episode describes the silly behaviour of a rich woman who is foolishly indulgent, perhaps because she is lonely. Do you think such people are merely silly, or can their actions cause harm to others?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Points for discussion:

- Such people are not merely silly; their actions can cause real harm.
- Mrs Pumphrey's "love" made Tricki fat, sick and almost killed him.
- Too much pampering harms the health of pets and children, makes them weak and dependent.
- Their money is wasted on luxuries while the real need (care, discipline, exercise) is ignored.

- Lonely people need company and good advice so that their love becomes sensible.

2 **Do you think there are also parents like Mrs Pumphrey?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Yes. Some parents pamper their children like Mrs Pumphrey. They give them junk food, sweets, costly gadgets and whatever they demand, and do not make them exercise or work. Such children may become unhealthy, lazy and spoilt, and may not learn discipline. Love is good, but it must be balanced with healthy habits and saying "no" when needed.

3 **What would you have done if you were: (i) a member of the staff in Mrs Pumphrey's household, (ii) a neighbour? What would your life have been like, in general?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

(i) Staff member: I would politely tell Mrs Pumphrey that Tricki needs less food and more walks, and I would take him out to play. My life would be busy, looking after the dog's coats, beds and bowls and obeying her wishes, perhaps a little boring and frustrating.

(ii) Neighbour: I would make friends with Mrs Pumphrey so that she is less lonely, and gently advise her to follow the vet's advice. I might let Tricki play with my children or pets. Life near her would be amusing, watching the fuss she makes over a little dog.

4 **What would you have done if you were in the narrator's place?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

I would have done much the same. I would explain to Mrs Pumphrey that overfeeding is the real cause of Tricki's illness, put him on a strict diet and give him plenty of exercise with other dogs. I would keep him away from his owner till he recovered. I would not accept so many gifts of wine and brandy, and I would honestly tell her that the cure was diet and exercise, not surgery, so that she does not repeat the mistake.

🎉 **Chapter 1 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**